

Pei's monument to Kennedy

Tall, white, simple shapes. Chalk cliffs, taut sails, lighthouse towers. Those are the kinds of objects that have stage presence in the vast deserted theater of an ocean-front setting. The Kennedy Library tries to match them.

For Ioh Ming Pei, the young architect chosen by Jacqueline Kennedy in 1964 because, she said then, "his best work, like John Kennedy's, was still to come," it has been a long wait. Today they break ground for Pei's library on Columbia Point and it looks as if the wait will have been worthwhile.

The architectural problem was simple to state, hard to solve: How to make, out of a small building (110,000 square feet in all, less than the area of four floors of the Pei firm's Hancock Tower), a building that has enough monumentality, enough symbolic force

New homes emphasizing energy saving

SO. DEERFIELD — Two custom housing manufacturers, Habitat and American Barn, have joined with a Connecticut firm, Blue/Sun Ltd. to produce a new series of homes emphasizing energy savings.

The new contemporary design series called "Energy Balanced" homes, is composed of modified versions of two Habitat models and five American Barn models.

Blue-Sun Ltd. has produced homes stressing energy savings and featuring solar systems. Customers purchasing Habitat or American Barn designs will have the option of adding a solar heating system.

Habitat and American Barn work through a network of builders and dealers primarily in the eastern part of the country.

The homes feature cathedral ceilings, sunken living rooms, skylights and decks. Option features include combination oil-fired woodburning furnaces, solar collectors and systems and added insulation application, according to company representatives.

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

to hold its own in so vast a setting, and not look like another yacht club or seaside motel.

Pei's solution is first to pull the building to its maximum possible height, second virtually to double its volume by adding to the useful spaces a purely ceremonial glass "pavilion" that is 100 feet high, and third to keep all shapes to a severe, geometry of circle, box, and triangle, like those lighthouses and sails it recalls.

The circle is the low, wheel-shaped wing, containing theaters where visitors see a movie about Kennedy. The box is the gray glass "pavilion," which you enter after you have finished all the displays, for a moment of what Pei calls "reflection" as you look out to sea. And the triangle is the archives tower, where the scholars will work. Tower and theater wing are pure white precast concrete panels.

All these elements interlock in an intellectually fascinating way that creates interior spaces, and overlooks within the building. Each floor of the archives tower, for example, juts into the pavilion so scholars using the research material can look into this amazing space, a space ten stories high with walls of gray glass behind a tubular space frame like a trellis, a space that is Pei's first attempt at what is really a religious or contemplative architectural experience.

Whether this is what a presidential library should be is another question. It's hard to believe the Kennedy memorial will have the poignancy of Hyde Park or the modest Coolidge homestead in Vermont, where you know you are looking at a real place the President once knew.

It wasn't I.M. Pei, it was others who decided that American presidents should engage in what New York Times critic Ada Louise Huxtable calls "the competitive Pantheon business." Maybe Americans, lacking palaces and "stately homes," really need these places. Certainly they visit in droves — about six million to date at Hyde Park. When the family hits the road for those three weeks in August, it needs goals to make each day seem meaningful.

A monument wasn't what John Kennedy had in mind when he picked

the original site in Cambridge. He planned a modest scholarly library and school of politics where he could work himself, something low and harmonious with the nearby Harvard dorms. It was after his death that others pushed the idea, at its most grandiose, into a World's Fair glass pyramid that looked, in close-grained Harvard Square, like a truck backed into a playground. No one even suggested where the public would park.

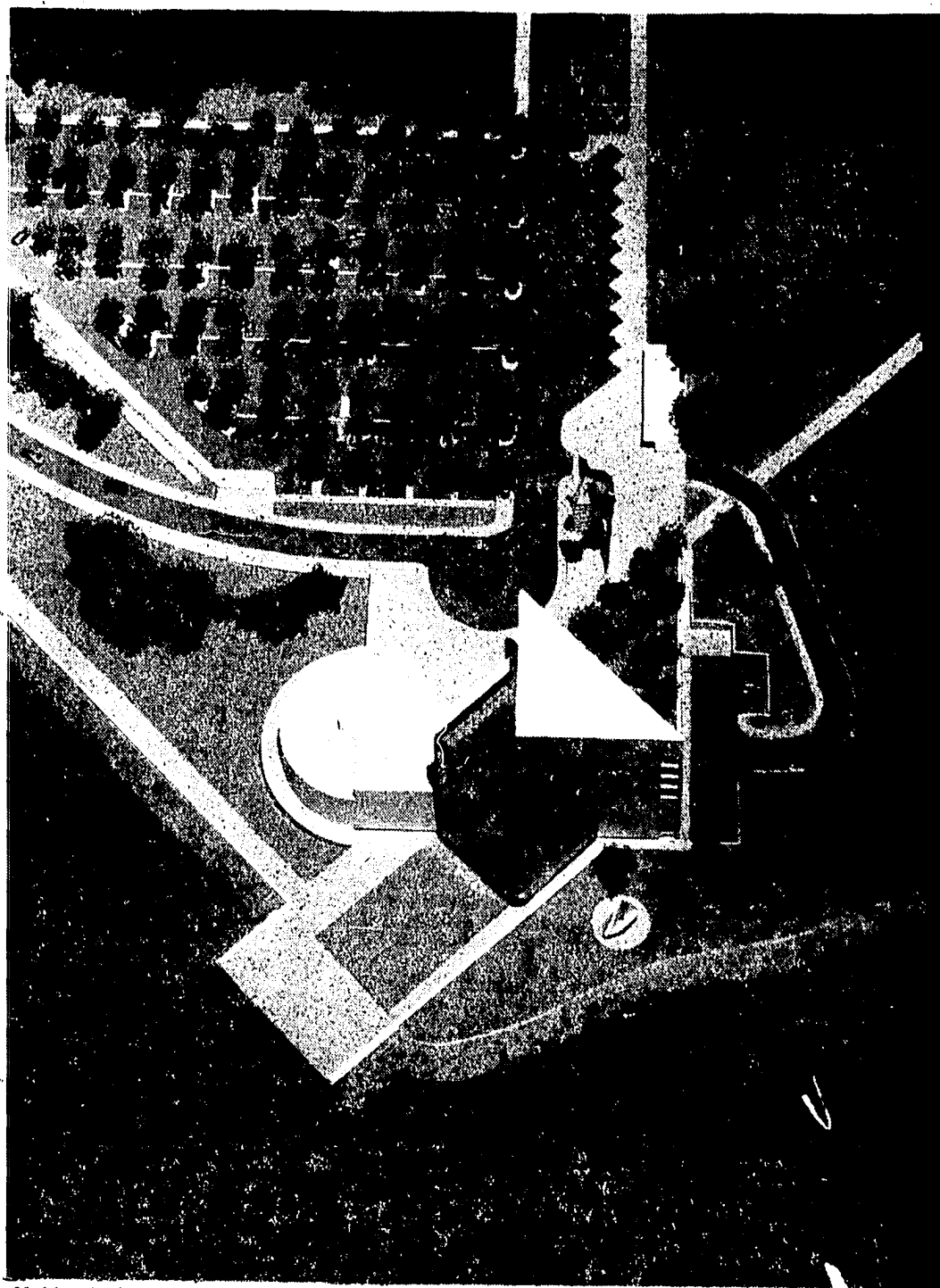
At Columbia Point there's room for everything, and its best, today, to leave the cosmic questions aside and say that, if a monument is what we want, Pei is the right architect and Columbia Point is the right site.

In a way, everyone has won. Harvard gets the MBTA land it schemed for so long. The Kennedy's get their tourist mecca. Scholars, perfectly happy in the archives now in Waltham, will be no less happy when they move here. Cambridge gets a park and maybe some sympathetic development. UMass gets prestige. Pei gets the chance to design a cut-glass-and-ivory sculpture in a great setting. Maybe, even, last on this list as on others, the residents of Columbia Point will win too.

The last is the unlikely. Funds to recycle the gorgeous Victorian pump-house nearby into a bookstore and community center for both university and housing project are stalled. A Peninsula Planning Committee now at work is only the latest in a string of such groups, so far futile, trying to find a future for Columbia Point. As ever with the Kennedy library, context is an issue. If Columbia Point and its President are not to be a replay of Upstairs/Downstairs, connections must be made.

We shouldn't forget the social issues but we shouldn't forget either that there's still such a thing as formal delight, space, sculpture, a particularly beautiful narcissistic kind of architecture. Too many buildings that should be background claw for attention. The Kennedy Library deserves it. One looks forward to visiting it with excitement.

This pale formal object, gathered to its full height on a lonely spit looking to sea, will be the last and most enduring of the Tall Ships.



Model of the John F. Kennedy Library on its Columbia Point site.